

EXCEL ACADEMY

CHANGING CULTURAL TRADITIONS

Class 11 History - Theme 5

Detailed Notes

Simple language • Complete coverage • Exam-oriented presentation

Fourteenth to seventeenth-century Europe: Renaissance, humanism, art, printing, religious reform and the Scientific Revolution

How to use these notes

- First learn the chapter flow: Italian city-states → humanism → realism and architecture → printing → new view of human beings → religious reform → science → debate over the idea of a Renaissance.
- Revise the timelines and key personalities separately. For long answers, use the ready-made answer frameworks near the end.
- Important terms are explained in simple words in the glossary.

1. Chapter at a Glance

- **Period:** The main cultural changes discussed took place in Europe from the fourteenth to the end of the seventeenth century.
- **Growth of towns:** Towns expanded, especially in Italy. An urban culture developed, and townspeople often considered themselves more “civilised” than rural people.
- **Centres of change:** Florence, Venice and Rome became major centres of trade, art, learning and political experiment.
- **Patronage:** Wealthy merchants, aristocrats and popes supported artists, architects and writers.
- **Printing:** Printed books and images spread ideas quickly and made private reading more common.
- **Humanism:** Scholars studied Greek and Roman texts and stressed human reason, debate, individual ability and life in this world.
- **Religion:** People questioned Church practices and increasingly treated faith as a matter of individual choice.
- **Science:** The old earth-centred picture of the universe was replaced by a sun-centred understanding based on observation and experiment.
- **Wider world:** New geographical knowledge weakened the belief that Europe and the Mediterranean were the centre of the world.

Meaning of “Renaissance”

- **Renaissance** literally means “rebirth”. From the nineteenth century, historians used it for the cultural changes that appeared to revive Greek and Roman learning.
- The term must be used carefully: modern historians argue that change was gradual, medieval Europe was not simply “dark”, and Europe also learned greatly from Arab, Persian, Indian, Central Asian and Chinese knowledge.

Jacob Burckhardt and the idea of Renaissance

- **Jacob Burckhardt (1818-1897)** was a Swiss historian at the University of Basle and a student of Leopold von Ranke.
- Ranke gave primary importance to states and politics and used official government papers. Burckhardt believed history must also study culture.
- In *The Civilisation of the Renaissance in Italy* (1860), Burckhardt used literature, architecture and painting to explain the rise of a new humanist culture in Italian towns.
- He described the “modern” person as an individual able to make decisions and develop skills, unlike his picture of medieval people as controlled by the Church.
- Later historians argue that Burckhardt made the difference between the Middle Ages and the Renaissance look too sharp.

2. Why Italian Cities Revived

Italy after the fall of the Western Roman Empire

- Many old political and cultural centres fell into ruin after the Western Roman Empire collapsed.
- Italy had no unified government. The Pope ruled his own state in Rome but was not a strong political figure at first.
- Western Europe developed feudal ties under the Latin Church; eastern Europe was under the Byzantine Empire; Islamic lands formed another large civilisation. Italy remained weak and divided.
- However, its location between these worlds later helped Italian ports and cities profit from expanding trade.

Trade and independent city-states

- Trade between the Byzantine Empire and Islamic countries revived Italian coastal ports.
- From the twelfth century, the opening of the Silk Route under the Mongols strengthened trade with China. Trade with western Europe also increased.
- Italian towns did not see themselves as parts of a single empire. They developed as independent **city-states**.
- **Florence and Venice** were republics. Many other towns were **court-cities** ruled by princes.
- **Venice and Genoa** became especially energetic commercial centres.
- The clergy and feudal lords were less politically dominant than elsewhere in Europe. Rich merchants and bankers took part in government.
- Participation in civic life strengthened the idea of **citizenship** and pride in one's city, even where military rulers held power.

Why did Italian towns experience humanism first?

- They were wealthy centres of Mediterranean and long-distance trade.
- Merchants and bankers had money to support education, buildings and art.
- Independent city-states encouraged active citizenship and competition among cities.
- Ancient Roman ruins and manuscripts were readily available in Italy.
- Early universities and contact with Byzantine and Islamic scholarship created a strong learning network.

The Venetian idea of government

- Cardinal Gasparo Contarini described Venice in *The Commonwealth and Government of Venice* (1534).
- A council held the main authority, and gentlemen above the age of twenty-five were admitted.
- Common people were excluded because the ruling class feared popular unrest.
- Contarini said rule should not depend only on wealth or only on a few highest nobles. It should include those noble by birth or recognised for virtue.
- Therefore, Venice used the language of a commonwealth, but political participation was limited mainly to privileged men.

3. Universities and Humanism

Early universities and legal studies

- Some of Europe's earliest universities were founded in Italian towns.
- Padua and Bologna were centres of legal studies from the eleventh century.
- Large-scale commerce required lawyers and **notaries** (people who prepared and authenticated legal records) to interpret rules and agreements.
- Law remained important, but scholars began to study it in relation to the culture and laws of ancient Rome.

Petrarch and the close reading of ancient texts

- **Francesco Petrarch (1304-1378)** represented the new approach.
- He treated antiquity as a separate and distinctive civilisation.
- He believed Greek and Roman thought could be understood best by reading the original words of ancient authors carefully.

- This method encouraged scholars to examine texts critically rather than accept later interpretations without question.

Meaning and curriculum of humanism

- Humanists believed that religious teaching alone could not provide all useful knowledge.
- By the early fifteenth century, a **humanist** meant a teacher of grammar, rhetoric, poetry, history and moral philosophy.
- The word came from the Latin *humanitas*, used by Cicero to mean culture.
- These subjects were not directly derived from religion. They developed an individual's ability through reading, discussion and debate.
- Giovanni Pico della Mirandola compared debate to physical exercise: debate strengthens the mind just as gymnastics strengthens the body.
- Humanist subjects slowly entered schools in Italy and other European countries, although schools at the time were meant only for boys.

Florence as an intellectual and artistic centre

- Florence became especially important in the fifteenth century, although it had not previously been a major centre of trade or learning.
- **Dante Alighieri (1265-1321)**, a lay writer on religious themes, helped give the city literary fame.
- **Giotto (1267-1337)** painted lifelike portraits that differed from the stiff figures of earlier art.
- Florence grew into one of Italy's most exciting centres of thought and artistic creativity.
- The expression "**Renaissance Man**" describes a person with many interests and skills. Some leading individuals combined the roles of scholar, diplomat, theologian and artist.

4. The Humanist View of History

- Humanists believed they were restoring "true civilisation" after a long period of decline following the fall of Rome.
- They called the thousand years after Rome's fall the **Middle Ages** or medieval period.
- They argued that the Church had controlled thought and hidden much Greek and Roman learning.
- They described the period from the fifteenth century as the **Modern Age**.
- Modern historians question this sharp division. Research shows that classical learning survived in medieval Europe and that cultural creativity cannot be neatly separated by century.
- Therefore, it is unfair to treat the entire medieval period as a "Dark Age".

Period used by humanists	Label
5th-14th centuries	Middle Ages
5th-9th centuries	Dark Ages
9th-11th centuries	Early Middle Ages
11th-14th centuries	Late Middle Ages
15th century onwards	Modern Age

Balanced exam point

- Write that humanists introduced this periodisation, but add that recent historians reject a rigid "dark medieval age versus bright Renaissance" contrast.
- This qualification shows historical understanding and is essential in long answers.

5. Science and Philosophy: The Arab Contribution

- Greek and Roman works were known to some medieval monks and clergy, but were not made widely available.
- In the fourteenth century, European scholars read Plato, Aristotle and other Greek thinkers through translations.
- Arab scholars had carefully preserved and translated ancient manuscripts. Plato was known as *Aflaton* and Aristotle as *Aristu* in Arabic.
- Greek translators also translated Arabic and Persian works into languages accessible to other Europeans.
- Knowledge travelled in natural science, mathematics, astronomy, medicine and chemistry.
- Ptolemy's *Almagest* shows this link: the Greek work was translated into Arabic, and even its later title includes the Arabic article "al".

Important Muslim scholars

Scholar	Contribution / importance
Ibn Sina (Avicenna), 980-1037	Physician and philosopher from Bukhara in Central Asia; highly respected in the Italian world.
Al-Razi (Rhazes)	Author of an important medical encyclopaedia.
Ibn Rushd (Averroes), 1126-1198	Philosopher from Spain who tried to reconcile philosophical knowledge with religious belief; Christian thinkers adopted his method.

Central conclusion

- The cultural changes of Europe were not produced by Europe alone. Arab, Persian and other Asian scholars preserved, developed and transmitted knowledge that later Europeans used.

6. Artists and Realism

How humanism spread through art

- Education was not the only carrier of humanism. Art, architecture and books communicated new ideas powerfully.
- Artists studied ancient Roman remains as eagerly as scholars studied ancient texts.
- Classical statues displayed carefully proportioned human bodies. Italian sculptors tried to continue this tradition.
- **Donatello (1386-1466)** created lifelike statues and broke new ground in 1416.
- Albrecht Durer argued that good art should be grounded in nature, geometry and careful copying from life.
- Religious faith continued, but it existed beside strong confidence in human ability and the search to understand nature.

Science behind realistic art

- **Anatomy:** Artists studied bone and muscle structures in medical schools to represent the body accurately.
- **Andreas Vesalius (1514-1564)**, a Belgian professor at Padua, was the first to dissect the human body. His work began modern physiology.
- **Geometry and perspective:** Geometry helped painters show depth and distance on a flat surface.
- **Light and shade:** Careful study of changing light created a three-dimensional effect.
- **Oil paint:** Oil colours produced richer and deeper colours than earlier methods.
- **Asian influence:** Chinese and Persian designs and colours appeared in costumes shown in paintings; these influences travelled through Mongol connections.
- Together, anatomy, geometry, physics and a strong sense of beauty created the Italian style called **realism**, which remained influential until the nineteenth century.

Leonardo da Vinci: a Renaissance Man

- **Leonardo da Vinci (1452-1519)** studied botany, anatomy, mathematics and art.
- He painted the *Mona Lisa* and *The Last Supper*.
- He observed birds for years and designed a flying machine because he dreamed of human flight.
- He called himself a “disciple of experiment”, showing the union of art, observation and science.

7. Architecture and the Status of Artists

- Rome revived strongly in the fifteenth century after the dispute involving rival popes ended in 1417.
- Politically stronger popes promoted the study of Roman history and supported new buildings.
- Archaeologists carefully excavated ancient ruins. Archaeology itself was a new skill.
- Architects revived features of imperial Roman buildings. This revived style is called **classical architecture**.
- Popes, rich merchants and aristocrats employed architects familiar with classical design. Painters and sculptors decorated buildings with paintings, statues and relief work.
- **Michelangelo Buonarroti (1475-1564)** worked as painter, sculptor and architect. Major works include the Sistine Chapel ceiling, *The Pieta*, and the dome of St Peter's Church in Rome.
- **Filippo Brunelleschi (1337-1446)** began as a sculptor and designed the famous Duomo, the dome of Florence Cathedral.
- A major social change was that artists became known by their individual names, rather than only as anonymous members of guilds or workshops.

Link with humanism

- Classical buildings revived Roman forms, while the fame of individual artists expressed the new respect for personal talent and achievement.

8. The First Printed Books

- Paintings, sculptures and buildings usually had to be seen in Italy, but written ideas could travel across borders.
- Europeans learned printing technology from the Chinese. Mongol courts helped European traders and diplomats become familiar with this and other innovations such as firearms, the compass and the abacus.
- Before printing, texts survived in only a few handwritten copies.
- In 1455, **Johannes Gutenberg (1400-1458)** printed 150 copies of the Bible. A monk would earlier have needed roughly the same time to hand-copy only one Bible.
- By 1500, many classical texts, mostly in Latin, had been printed in Italy.
- Students could buy books and did not depend only on lecture notes.
- Ideas, opinions and information moved faster and reached hundreds of readers.
- Private ownership of books encouraged the habit of individual reading.
- Printing was the chief reason Italian humanist culture spread rapidly across the Alps from the late fifteenth century.

Impact of printing - answer in four words

- **Speed:** ideas circulated rapidly.
- **Reach:** one text reached many readers.
- **Access:** books could be bought and read privately.
- **Reform:** classical, religious and scientific debates crossed regional boundaries.

9. A New Concept of Human Beings

- Humanist culture reduced the complete control of religion over everyday life, although most Italians remained religious.
- Material wealth, power and worldly glory were no longer always treated as sinful.
- **Francesco Barbaro (1390-1454)** defended the acquisition of wealth as a virtue.
- **Lorenzo Valla (1406-1457)**, in *On Pleasure*, criticised the Christian warning against pleasure and linked historical study with the effort to live a better life.
- People paid greater attention to manners, polite speech, correct dress and the skills expected from a cultured person.
- Humanists argued that people could shape their own lives through more than the search for wealth or power.
- They viewed human nature as **many-sided**, challenging the fixed three-order picture of feudal society.

Machiavelli on human nature

- **Niccolo Machiavelli** discussed human qualities in *The Prince* (1513).
- He described people as capable of opposite qualities: generosity or miserliness, compassion or cruelty, courage or cowardice, faithfulness or deceit.
- He believed human desires were unlimited and people often revealed a vicious side.
- In his view, **self-interest** was the strongest motive behind human action.
- His approach examined politics and behaviour as they actually existed, not merely as religious or moral ideals said they should exist.

10. The Aspirations and Position of Women

General limitations

- The new language of individuality and citizenship mainly benefited men and excluded most women.
- Aristocratic men controlled public life and family decisions.
- Sons were educated for family business, public life or service in the Church.
- A woman's dowry could be invested in the family business, but she usually had no control over business decisions.
- Marriages often created or strengthened business alliances.
- A daughter for whom a sufficient dowry could not be arranged might be sent to a convent.
- Women were mainly expected to manage the household.

Women in merchant families

- Shopkeepers' wives often helped run shops.
- Wives in merchant and banking families managed business when male relatives travelled.
- A merchant's early death could force his widow to take a larger public and economic role than most aristocratic women had.

Educated women who challenged limits

- **Cassandra Fedele (1465-1558)** argued that women should pursue literary studies even when society offered them no reward or dignity for doing so.
- She mastered Greek and Latin and was invited to deliver speeches at the University of Padua.
- Fedele and other Venetian women criticised a republic that defined freedom mainly according to men's desires.
- **Isabella d'Este (1474-1539)**, Marchesa of Mantua, ruled the state while her husband was absent. Her court became famous for intellectual brilliance.
- Women writers demanded education, property and economic power so that women could build an independent identity.

The male ideal described by Castiglione

- In *The Courtier* (1528), Balthasar Castiglione said women should appear soft, delicate, graceful and distinctly feminine.
- He accepted that women needed intelligence, prudence, good manners and mental virtues, but still restricted them to behaviour and activities considered suitable for women.
- Thus Fedele demanded learning and dignity, while Castiglione's ideal remained shaped by upper-class male expectations.

Exam judgement

- Renaissance individualism was incomplete: it celebrated human potential but did not offer equal public freedom to women.
- The women discussed in the chapter mainly belonged to literate, prosperous or courtly groups; their experience did not represent all women.

11. Debates within Christianity

Northern humanism and criticism of the Church

- Trade, travel, conquest and diplomacy connected Italy with the wider world. The wealthy and educated copied the new culture, but most ordinary people could not read and received few of its ideas.
- In northern Europe, humanists studied Greek and Roman classics along with early Christian writings.
- Unlike Italy, where professional scholars led humanism, many northern humanists were Church members.
- They wanted Christianity to return to the simplicity of its earliest texts and rejected rituals they considered later additions.
- They described human beings as free and rational agents able to seek happiness in the present world.

Erasmus, Thomas More and Church abuses

- **Thomas More (1478-1535)** in England and **Erasmus (1466-1536)** in Holland believed the Church had become greedy.
- They criticised the extraction of money from ordinary people.
- A major abuse was the sale of **indulgences** - documents said to release buyers from the burden of their sins.
- Printed Bibles in local languages enabled Christians to see that such practices had no clear support in scripture.
- Peasants opposed Church taxes, while princes resented Church interference in government.
- Humanist scholars proved that the **Donation of Constantine**, used to justify the clergy's judicial and financial authority, was a later forgery.

Martin Luther and the Protestant Reformation

- In 1517, the German monk **Martin Luther (1483-1546)** began a campaign against the Catholic Church.
- He argued that a person did not need a priest to establish contact with God.
- He taught that **faith alone** could guide a person to a good life and salvation.
- The movement became known as the **Protestant Reformation**. Churches in Germany and Switzerland broke from the Pope and the Catholic Church.
- **Ulrich Zwingli (1484-1531)** and later **Jean Calvin (1509-1564)** spread reform ideas in Switzerland.
- Merchants supported reformers, so Protestantism became especially influential in towns. Catholic influence remained stronger in many rural regions.

Radical reformers, peasants and political resistance

- The **Anabaptists** linked salvation with an end to social oppression.
- They argued that because God created all people equal, people should not pay oppressive taxes and should choose their own priests.
- These ideas appealed to peasants suffering under feudalism.
- Luther rejected this radical programme and asked German rulers to crush the peasant revolt of 1525.
- Radical Protestant ideas survived in France. Persecuted Protestants claimed that people had the right to remove an oppressive ruler and choose another.
- Eventually, France and several other regions allowed Protestants to worship according to their beliefs.
- In England, the monarch became head of the Church after relations with the Pope were ended.

William Tyndale and the Bible in the mother tongue

- **William Tyndale (1494-1536)**, an English supporter of Luther, translated the Bible into English.
- He argued that ordinary people needed scripture in their own language so they could understand its meaning directly and not be controlled by false teaching or superstition.

Catholic reform and the Jesuits

- The Catholic Church also reformed itself from within.
- Church leaders in Spain and Italy stressed simple living and service to the poor.
- **Ignatius Loyola** founded the **Society of Jesus** in 1540 to resist Protestantism.
- Its members, called **Jesuits**, served the poor and sought knowledge of other cultures.

Main Protestant criticisms of the Catholic Church

- Greed and collection of money from ordinary believers.
- Sale of indulgences.
- Unnecessary rituals not supported by early Christian texts.
- Priestly control over the believer's relationship with God.
- Church taxes, political interference and questionable claims to judicial and financial power.
- Keeping scripture away from ordinary people by resisting translation into local languages.

12. The Copernican Revolution

Old earth-centred belief

- Traditional Christian teaching presented the earth as sinful and fixed at the centre of the universe.
- The celestial planets were believed to move around this immobile earth.

Copernicus and the sun-centred system

- **Nicolaus Copernicus (1473-1543)** argued that the planets, including the earth, revolve around the sun.
- Although a devout Christian, he feared the response of conservative Church leaders and did not want his manuscript *De revolutionibus (The Rotation)* printed.
- On his deathbed, he handed the manuscript to his follower Joachim Rheticus.
- The theory was not accepted quickly; the change in worldview took more than half a century.

Kepler, Galileo and Newton

- **Johannes Kepler (1571-1630)** explained in *Cosmographical Mystery* that planets move around the sun in ellipses, not perfect circles.
- **Galileo Galilei (1564-1642)** supported the idea of a moving or dynamic universe in *The Motion*.
- **Isaac Newton** brought the revolution to its climax with the theory of gravitation.
- Together, these ideas ended the old division between a fixed sinful earth and perfect heavens.

Why was it a revolution?

- It displaced the earth and human beings from the physical centre of the universe.
- It replaced inherited authority with mathematical explanation, observation and investigation.
- It helped create a new picture of nature governed by discoverable laws.

13. Reading the Universe and the Scientific Revolution

- Galileo said the Bible guides people toward heaven but does not explain in detail how the heavens physically work.
- The new thinkers separated **knowledge**, based on observation and experiment, from **belief**.
- Investigation rapidly expanded in fields later called physics, chemistry and biology.
- Historians call this new method and body of knowledge the **Scientific Revolution**.
- Some sceptics and non-believers replaced God with Nature as the source of creation.
- Some believers continued to believe in God but imagined a distant creator who did not directly control everyday material life.
- Scientific societies carried science into public life by organising lectures and public experiments.
- The **Royal Society of London** was formed in 1662 to promote natural knowledge.
- The chapter notes the establishment of a scientific academy in Paris around 1670; the timeline records an Academy of Sciences in Paris in 1673.

14. Was There Really a European Renaissance?

Why the traditional view is questioned

- Historian Peter Burke argued that Burckhardt exaggerated the break between the Renaissance and the preceding centuries.

- Greek and Roman learning had not disappeared completely in medieval Europe.
- Renaissance scholars and artists did not replace Christianity with a purely pre-Christian worldview. Religion remained central in people's lives.
- Describing the Renaissance as creative and the Middle Ages as gloomy is an oversimplification.
- Many developments associated with the Renaissance can be traced to the twelfth and thirteenth centuries.
- Some historians even identify a comparable literary and artistic flowering in ninth-century France.

The non-European contribution

- European change was not shaped only by Greece and Rome.
- Asian technologies and skills had advanced beyond many ancient Greek and Roman achievements.
- Islamic expansion and Mongol conquests connected Asia and North Africa with Europe through trade and learning.
- Europeans learned from India, Arabia, Iran, Central Asia and China.
- Navigation techniques connected larger parts of the world and allowed longer sea voyages.
- Older historians often failed to acknowledge these debts because they wrote from a Europe-centred viewpoint.

Changes that were genuinely important

- **Public and private spheres separated gradually:** government and formal religion belonged to the public sphere; family life and personal religion increasingly belonged to the private sphere.
- **The individual gained a distinct identity:** a person was not only a member of a social order or guild. Artists, thinkers and writers became known by name.
- **Long-term political result:** in the eighteenth century, individuality would contribute to the idea that all individuals should have equal political rights.
- **Regional identities strengthened:** different European regions developed separate identities based on language.
- **Europe moved toward language-based states:** the older unity based on the Roman Empire, Latin and Christianity gradually weakened.

Best concluding judgement

- The Renaissance was not a sudden rebirth after a completely dark age. It was a gradual transformation built from medieval continuities, classical recovery, expanding towns and trade, printing, and knowledge exchanged with many non-European societies.

15. Master Timeline

Year	Event and significance
1300	Humanism taught at Padua University
1341	Petrarch crowned Poet Laureate in Rome
1349	University established in Florence
1390	Chaucer's <i>Canterbury Tales</i> published
1416	Donatello creates groundbreaking lifelike sculpture
1436	Brunelleschi designs the Duomo in Florence
1453	Ottoman Turks defeat the Byzantine ruler of Constantinople
1454/1455	Gutenberg prints the Bible using movable type; the text describes 150 copies in 1455
1484	Portuguese mathematicians calculate latitude by observing the sun
1492	Columbus reaches America
1495	Leonardo da Vinci paints <i>The Last Supper</i>
1512	Michelangelo completes the Sistine Chapel ceiling
1513	Machiavelli's <i>The Prince</i>
1516	Thomas More's <i>Utopia</i> published
1517	Martin Luther writes the Ninety-Five Theses
1522	Luther translates the Bible into German
1525	Peasant uprising in Germany; rulers suppress it with Luther's support
1528	Castiglione's <i>The Courtier</i>
1540	Ignatius Loyola founds the Society of Jesus
1543	Vesalius writes <i>On Anatomy</i> ; Copernicus's work appears
1559	Anglican Church established with the English monarch as head
1569	Mercator prepares a cylindrical map of the earth
1582	Gregorian calendar introduced by Pope Gregory XIII
1628	William Harvey connects the heart with blood circulation
1662	Royal Society formed in London
1670/1673	Scientific academy established in Paris (chapter narrative/timeline)
1687	Newton's <i>Principia Mathematica</i> published

16. Key Personalities - One-Line Revision

Person	Remember for
Jacob Burckhardt	Defined the Italian Renaissance as a new humanist culture and expanded history beyond politics.
Francesco Petrarch	Promoted close reading of ancient Greek and Roman authors.
Dante Alighieri	Lay writer whose work helped give Florence literary fame.
Giotto	Painted lifelike figures instead of older stiff forms.
Pico della Mirandola	Praised debate as an exercise that strengthens the mind.
Ibn Sina / al-Razi	Major medical and philosophical authorities known in Europe.
Ibn Rushd	Tried to reconcile philosophy and religion.
Donatello	Pioneer of lifelike Renaissance sculpture.
Leonardo da Vinci	Artist-scientist and "disciple of experiment".
Andreas Vesalius	Human dissection and the beginning of modern physiology.
Michelangelo	Painter, sculptor and architect of major works in Rome.
Brunelleschi	Designer of Florence Cathedral's Duomo.
Johannes Gutenberg	Introduced the first European printing press and printed the Bible.
Machiavelli	Explained human conduct and politics through self-interest and real behaviour.
Cassandra Fedele	Defended women's right to humanist education.
Isabella d'Este	Ruler and patron whose court at Mantua became intellectually famous.
Thomas More / Erasmus	Christian humanists who criticised Church greed and abuses.
Martin Luther	Led the Protestant Reformation and taught salvation through faith.
Zwingli / Calvin	Spread Protestant reform in Switzerland.
Ignatius Loyola	Founded the Society of Jesus or Jesuits.
Copernicus	Placed the planets, including earth, in orbit around the sun.
Kepler	Showed that planetary orbits are elliptical.
Galileo	Supported a dynamic universe and experimental investigation.
Isaac Newton	Explained gravitation and completed the new scientific picture.

17. Important Terms and Meanings

Term	Simple meaning
Renaissance	"Rebirth"; name given to major cultural changes and renewed interest in classical learning.
Humanism	Study and outlook stressing classical texts, reason, debate, human skills and worldly life.
City-state	An independent city together with the territory it controls.
Republic	A state not ruled as the hereditary possession of a monarch.
Patron	A wealthy supporter who finances artists, writers or scholars.
Notary	An authorised writer and keeper of legal records and agreements.
Antiquity	The ancient Greek and Roman past.
Perspective	Artistic method that creates depth and distance on a flat surface.
Realism	Representation of people and objects in a lifelike, accurate manner.
Classical architecture	Architecture reviving forms used in ancient Greece and imperial Rome.
Guild	Association of people practising the same craft or trade.
Indulgence	Church document claimed to reduce the burden of a person's sins.
Protestant Reformation	Movement that challenged Catholic authority and created separate Protestant churches.
Jesuits	Members of the Society of Jesus founded by Ignatius Loyola.
Heliocentric	Sun-centred model in which planets revolve around the sun.
Scientific Revolution	New study of nature based on observation, experiment and mathematical reasoning.
Public sphere	Area of government and formal religion.
Private sphere	Area of family life, personal belief and individual identity.
Eurocentrism	Viewing history mainly from a European perspective and undervaluing other regions.

18. High-Value Comparisons

Humanism in Italy and northern Europe

Point	Italy	Northern Europe
Main leaders	Professional scholars, artists and teachers	Many scholars connected with the Church
Main focus	Greek-Roman classics, civic life, art and individual ability	Classical works plus early Christian texts
Religious aim	Reduced religious control but generally remained religious	Reform Christianity by removing later rituals and abuses
Major effect	New culture of art, education and individual achievement	Criticism of Church greed and support for religious reform

Medieval model and new Renaissance tendencies

Older model	New tendency
Identity tied mainly to social order, Church or guild	The individual increasingly valued in his or her own right
Learning centred heavily on theology	Humanities, classical texts, debate and worldly subjects expanded
Art often symbolic and artists less individually famous	Realistic art and named artists with personal fame
Earth-centred religious universe	Sun-centred, law-governed universe studied through experiment
Latin and Church helped unite Europe	Regional languages and separate state identities strengthened

Traditional and revised interpretations of Renaissance

Traditional interpretation	Revised interpretation
A sharp rebirth after a dark medieval age	Gradual change with important medieval continuities
Recovery mainly of Greece and Rome	Also depended on Asian, Arab, Persian and other knowledge
Christian worldview was replaced	Religion remained powerful while new ideas grew beside it
Uniquely European achievement	Result of growing interregional trade, translation and knowledge exchange

19. Exam Answer Frameworks

A. Features of humanist thought

- **Introduction:** Humanism was a cultural and educational outlook that developed strongly in Italian towns and drew inspiration from Greek and Roman learning.
- **Classical study:** Close reading of original texts; respect for antiquity.
- **New subjects:** Grammar, rhetoric, poetry, history and moral philosophy.
- **Reason and debate:** Knowledge grew through discussion, criticism and intellectual exercise.
- **Individual ability:** Human beings could develop many talents and shape their lives.
- **Worldly life:** Wealth, pleasure, good manners and civic achievement received greater acceptance.
- **Art and science:** The body and nature were studied carefully; realism joined beauty with anatomy and geometry.
- **Qualification:** Humanism did not end religion, and its freedom largely excluded women and ordinary illiterate people.
- **Conclusion:** It widened knowledge beyond theology and helped create a new respect for individual reason and achievement.

B. How did the world appear different to seventeenth-century Europeans?

- **Universe:** Earth was no longer seen as fixed at the centre; it was one planet in a sun-centred system.
- **Planetary motion:** Kepler explained elliptical orbits; Galileo supported a dynamic universe; Newton explained gravitation.
- **Method:** Observation, experiment and mathematics became the basis of knowledge.
- **Nature:** The world increasingly appeared to operate according to discoverable natural laws.
- **Religion:** Some people separated scientific explanation from scripture; some imagined a distant God, while others became sceptical.
- **Institutions:** scientific societies in London and Paris made experiments part of public culture.
- **Geography:** navigation and overseas discoveries weakened the Europe-centred Mediterranean worldview.

- **Conclusion:** Europeans increasingly saw a vast, dynamic and connected universe that could be investigated by human reason.

C. Explain the impact of printing

- Begin with the contrast between a handwritten manuscript and Gutenberg's 150 printed Bibles.
- Explain wider availability, lower dependence on lecture notes, private reading and faster circulation.
- Connect printing with the spread of humanism across the Alps, Bible translations, Church criticism and scientific debate.
- Conclude that printing transformed a local idea into a movement capable of reaching many regions.

D. Assess the position of women during the Renaissance

- State the contradiction: individual freedom expanded, but mainly for men.
- Explain aristocratic marriage, dowry, household duties and exclusion from public decisions.
- Add the relatively larger business role of merchants' wives and widows.
- Use Fedele and Isabella d'Este as examples of women claiming education, power and identity.
- Compare Fedele's demand for learning with Castiglione's restricted ideal of feminine behaviour.
- Conclude that a few privileged women challenged limits, but gender equality was not achieved.

E. Was the Renaissance a sharp break with the past?

- Present Burckhardt's view of a new modern and individualistic culture.
- Then give the criticism: classical learning survived in the Middle Ages; religion remained important; several developments began in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries.
- Add the often-overlooked contributions of Islamic lands and Asia.
- Recognise real changes: printing, individual identity, public-private separation, scientific method and language-based states.
- Conclude that the period was important but should be understood as a gradual, connected transformation rather than a sudden rebirth.

20. Rapid Revision Sheet

Ten facts to remember

- Italian trade, city-states and wealthy patrons created the setting for cultural change.
- Humanism expanded education beyond religious study and encouraged debate.
- Petrarch promoted close reading of ancient authors.
- Arab and Persian scholars preserved and transmitted classical and scientific knowledge.
- Realistic art combined anatomy, geometry, light, oil painting and observation.
- Printing multiplied texts and carried ideas across regions.
- Renaissance individuality largely excluded women from equal citizenship.
- Church abuses and vernacular Bibles helped produce the Protestant Reformation.
- Copernicus, Kepler, Galileo and Newton transformed the understanding of the universe.
- The Renaissance was neither purely European nor a complete break from the medieval past.

Common mistakes to avoid

- Do not write that religion disappeared during the Renaissance.
- Do not describe every medieval century as culturally dark.
- Do not present the Renaissance as created only by Europeans.
- Do not confuse humanism with rejection of all faith; many humanists were religious.
- Do not say all women gained freedom; the chapter stresses their continued exclusion.
- Do not stop at Copernicus when explaining the scientific revolution; include Kepler, Galileo, Newton, experiment and scientific societies.

Source note: These notes are based only on the supplied NCERT Class 11 History chapter, "Changing Cultural Traditions" (Reprint 2026-27).